FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

With India and Pakistan going eyeball to eyeball after the Pahalgam terror attack, the threat of a military conflagration hangs over the subcontinent. This week, we focus on India's Antagonist No. 1, General Asim Munir. Not only because New Delhi deems Pakistan's army chief and de facto helmsman as the one who authorised the Pahalgam massacre. His thoughts and actions form a crucial variable. Unfortunately, despite proclaiming to be a democracy, the all-powerful nature of the army chief's post has been a defining feature of Pakistan. After Partition, the new Islamic state followed its own twisted tryst with destiny. Of the 77 years it has been in existence, Pakistan has been under direct military rule for 33 long years, in three phases. But that number is misleading, because the army has always reigned supreme, with only rare interludes where civilian leadership has dared to take on the bosses at the Rawalpindi GHQ. Like nine pins, each of those challengers who deluded themselves of being more powerful than the army were deposed. Imran Khan was the last prime minister who suffered this fate when he got into a conflict with the army and was summarily deposed in a 'parliamentary coup' in April 2022.

The incumbent prime minister, Shehbaz Sharif, is seen as pliant. The ruling coalition of arch-rivals, the Pakistan People's Party lumped together with the Pakistan Muslim League of Sharif, is a device Munir concocted to keep out Imran, who remains Pakistan's most popular politician. So decision-making is by and large centralised in Munir. And he has not been hands-off or in an ivory tower. Since taking over in November 2022, he has worked toward resolving the polycrisis in Pakistan: a moving fireball whose elements include political disorder, economic collapse and radical insurgencies. Not content with just being a security czar, he has become economic troubleshooter and political arbiter.

Munir, though, is an exception in the long line of self-aggrandising Pakistan army chiefs. Almost a copybook 'good boy', a far cry from the westernised, whisky-swilling generals of the country's early decades, he rose up the ranks the hard way, from outside the charmed circle, with no pedigree. He's an alumnus of the Officers Training School and not of the Pakistan Military Academy, the hallowed alma mater of eight of his predecessors. An accomplished soldier who served in Siachen and also won his nation's highest military honour, Munir is also the first army chief who served as director-general of both Military Intelligence and ISI.

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Not given to flaunting pelf, he has clamped down on the widespread corruption in the country. His falling out with Imran and subsequent sacking as ISI chief came after he brought to the then PM's notice allegations of his wife Bushra Bibi's ill-gotten wealth. Born into a humble but respected *hafiz* family, he carries forward its tradition of being able to recite the Quran by heart. And he brings its verses into geopolitics. To that extent, he is in the mould of Gen. Zia-ul-Haq, Pakistan's first Islamist army overlord. Pakistan could have chosen a different course under him. Munir's initial steps were in sync with the pragmatist line of his predecessor Qamar Bajwa, who by the end of his term in November 2022 was inclined to reconcile with India and focus on fixing Pakistan's decaying economy. Before Pahalgam, Munir did not seem to endorse radical Islamist terror; he was hostile toward the Pakistani Taliban jihadists and their Afghan brethren.

But he soon began to exhibit a troubling duality, equating the army's role with being a defender of the faith. In August 2023, addressing a grand jirga of Pashtun tribesmen in Peshawar, he said, "We are waging jihad in the path of Allah and success will be ours, Allah willing. The Pakistan army's objective and principle is to be *shahid* (martyr) or *ghazi* (one who takes part in jihad)."

Despite the tough talk, the army and Munir's reputation have suffered on the security front, specially after the Baloch train hijack. Political dissent and economic gloom accentuate that loss of stature. Kashmir's economic and political revival must hurt too. Feeling besieged, Munir reverted to the age-old tactic of Pakistani generals of raising tensions with India to divert attention from their own woes and rally support among the masses. In a speech in Islamabad a week before the Pahalgam attacks, he harked back to the two-nation theory, claiming Hindus and Muslims have irreconcilable differences, and vowed to free Kashmir, calling it Pakistan's "jugular vein". This was language even Zia did not use. That's why we are calling him 'Jihadi General'. In this week's cover story, Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa warns that Munir is mixing a deadly cocktail of religion, politics and terror with brinkmanship. India must heed this while giving Pakistan and its recalcitrant general a fitting response for its Pahalgam perfidy.

(Aroon Purie)